PRACTITIONER HANDBOOKS · B1

Lodge Mentor’s Guide

The full guide for appointed Lodge Mentors in the Masonic Province of Hertfordshire: the roles, the principles, the member’s journey stage by stage, learning, One Journey, retention, escalation, migration, working with other officers, Provincial support, and the Lodge Mentor’s year.

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Companions	Lodge Mentor’s Short Guide (B1a) · Personal Mentor’s Guide · The Hertfordshire Mentoring Handbook (B0)

Foreword

If you have been appointed Lodge Mentor, congratulations. In my view yours is one of the most important offices in any Lodge. Not because it carries rank, but because it carries responsibility for the wellbeing, learning and long-term enjoyment of every member in your care.

This guide is here to support you in that role. It is practical rather than prescriptive. It offers guidance and prompts, not rigid instruction. Every Lodge is different and every member is unique. What matters is not that you follow a formula, but that every Brother in your Lodge feels welcomed, supported, informed and valued.

The Provincial Mentoring Framework is clear that mentoring is not a time-limited activity confined to candidates and new members. It is a continuous responsibility that follows a member through his whole Masonic journey: from interview and Initiation, through progressive office, into the Chair and well beyond it. It applies just as much to the Brother who joins us from another Lodge as to the man we initiate ourselves.

In Hertfordshire we have the Mentoring Principles as a single page that every mentoring document quotes. You will find them in Section 3. Everything else in this guide is an attempt to show what they look like in practice, on a Lodge night, in a conversation, in the weeks between meetings.

You are not alone in this role. The Province is here to support you, and so is a growing library of companion documents, from the Personal Mentor's Guide to the Retention, Retrieval and Migration Guide. Please make use of the induction, the monthly call and the peer support available, and never hesitate to seek advice. Asking for help is a strength, not a weakness.

Thank you for the time and care you give to this work. Freemasonry in Hertfordshire is stronger because of Lodge Mentors like you.

Wes Pierce

Deputy Provincial Grand Mentor, Province of Hertfordshire

September 2026

As our Provincial Grand Mentor says "Freemasonry must be fun"

A man who is enjoying himself attends. A man who attends participates. A man who participates belongs. And a man who belongs does not resign.

1 Introduction

This guide has been prepared by the Provincial Grand Mentor's office to help Lodge Mentors carry out their role effectively and with confidence. It sits within UGLE's Building Together framework, in which mentoring owns the ENGAGE theme, and it aligns fully with the Provincial Mentoring Framework.

The guide does not replace Lodge autonomy or individual judgement. Lodges differ in character, size and tradition, and what works in one may need adapting in another. This is not a rulebook. It is a practical framework and a source of prompts and ideas.

Mentoring in Hertfordshire rests on a simple idea: every member, at every stage of his Masonic journey, deserves to be properly prepared, thoughtfully guided, actively supported and continuously enlightened. That is not the job of one man. It is a shared Lodge culture, co-ordinated by the Lodge Mentor.

1.1 Who this guide is for

It is written for appointed Lodge Mentors. It will also be useful to:

- Personal Mentors supporting individual members (who have their own companion, the Personal Mentor's Guide)

- Worshipful Masters and Wardens, who oversee the welfare of the Lodge
- Lodge Membership Officers, Almoners and Secretaries working alongside the mentoring team
- Any experienced Mason supporting the Lodge's newer members

1.2 Companion documents

This guide is one part of a library. Where another document owns a topic in full, this guide summarises and points to it rather than repeating it.

Document	What it is for
The Hertfordshire Mentoring Principles	The one-page canon. The four principles, their order and their definitions. Quoted in Section 3.
Provincial Mentoring Framework	The Provincial strategy: team structure, the New Initiate Pathway, One Journey, retention and reporting.
Personal Mentor's Guide	The one-to-one companion for Personal Mentors. Give a copy to every Personal Mentor you appoint.
Personal Mentoring Plan	The per-member record and action checklist. One for every Brother under mentoring.
Mentor Meeting Guide	A conversation guide for one-to-one meetings, stage by stage.
Stage Checklists	One-page checklists for Initiation night, the second meeting, before Passing and Raising, Installation and first LoI.
Warning Signs and Early Intervention card	A pocket card of the warning signs and the four steps.
Retention, Retrieval and Migration Guide	The owner-document for warning signs, intervention, resignations, Rule 183, unattached Brethren and migration.

1.3 Abbreviations used in this guide

LM	Lodge Mentor
PM	Personal Mentor
ProvGMen	Provincial Grand Mentor

ProvGM	Provincial Grand Master
APGMen	Assistant Provincial Grand Mentor (one per APGM area)
UGLE	United Grand Lodge of England
WM	Worshipful Master
EA / FC / MM	Entered Apprentice / Fellow Craft / Master Mason
LoI	Lodge of Instruction
DC	Director of Ceremonies
RA	Royal Arch
DAWG	Daily Advancement WhatsApp Group, run by the Provincial Mentoring Team

Note: the abbreviation "PGM" is not used in Hertfordshire mentoring documents because it is read two ways. ProvGM is the Provincial Grand Master; ProvGMen is the Provincial Grand Mentor.

2 Understanding the Roles

Good mentoring depends on everyone knowing who does what. There are two distinct but complementary roles in the Lodge, and a wider Provincial team behind them. Clarity prevents duplication and makes sure no member falls through the gaps.

2.1 The Lodge Mentor

The Lodge Mentor co-ordinates mentoring within the Lodge. He is not the Personal Mentor to every member; that would be neither practical nor appropriate. His job is to make sure mentoring happens, and happens well.

The Lodge Mentor:

- Ensures every new and joining member is assigned a suitable Personal Mentor, promptly
- Supports and guides Personal Mentors, and gives each one a copy of the Personal Mentor's Guide
- Opens a Personal Mentoring Plan for each member under mentoring and reviews progress against it
- Keeps an overview of mentoring across the Lodge and watches for patterns

- Is the Lodge's link to the Province on mentoring matters, including the monthly call
- Escalates concerns to the Worshipful Master or the Province when appropriate
- Keeps simple, secure records and briefs his successor
- Briefs the whole Lodge, at least once a year, on what mentoring is and why it matters

It is beneficial if a Lodge Mentor can serve for a sustained period, ideally three to five years. Continuity builds experience and avoids restarting the system with every change of appointment. Part of the job is to develop the man who will follow you.

Key principle

The Lodge Mentor is an organiser and co-ordinator. He ensures mentoring happens; he does not need to do it all himself. Sharing the work across suitable, experienced Brethren makes it sustainable and more effective.

2.2 The Personal Mentor

The Personal Mentor supports one member, one-to-one. He is the member's guide, friend and first point of contact through the early stages of his journey, and often beyond.

Choose him for time, temperament and the potential for friendship, not for seniority. He should be:

- A suitably experienced Mason who knows the Lodge well
- A good match for the personality and circumstances of the member
- Willing to give time, and to keep in touch between meetings
- A good listener: patient and non-judgemental
- Able to guide without patronising, and willing to say "I don't know, but I'll find out"

The Personal Mentor is not required to know everything, and should never speculate or pass on unverified information. When unsure he consults the Lodge Mentor or points the member to an authoritative source such as Solomon.

Assign thoughtfully. Consider compatibility of character, shared interests, proximity and availability. The Proposer often makes an excellent Personal Mentor because trust already exists; but not always, and the choice is yours.

2.3 The Provincial Mentoring Team

Behind every Lodge Mentor stands the Provincial team: the Provincial Grand Mentor, the Deputy Provincial Grand Mentor and five Assistant Provincial Grand Mentors, one for each APGM area. Your Assistant Provincial Grand Mentor is your nearest point of contact. He will visit, ideally at Initiations, and is there to help, never to inspect. Section 11 describes the support available.

3 The Hertfordshire Mentoring Principles

The four principles below are quoted from The Hertfordshire Mentoring Principles, the Province's canonical one-page statement. They are reproduced here exactly, and every mentoring document in Hertfordshire quotes the same text.

Our vision

"Every member, in every Lodge, experiences Freemasonry as welcoming, supportive, engaging, and personally rewarding"

Mentoring in Hertfordshire is a culture, not a programme. It supports a Brother from his first enquiry into Freemasonry through every stage of his Masonic journey - properly prepared, thoughtfully guided, actively supported, and continuously enlightened - so that no Brother walks alone.

PREPARE	Ensuring members are ready for each stage of their Masonic journey. This begins before interview and continues through practical preparation for ceremonies, office, and progression - ensuring members understand what to expect before it happens.
GUIDE	Providing accurate, clear, and timely information and support. Good guidance is honest and grounded in authoritative sources. It dispels myths, answers questions openly, and helps members navigate an unfamiliar world with confidence - without creating dependency.
SUPPORT	Being present, responsive, and compassionate throughout. Support is not only practical; it is relational. Members who feel cared for and valued are far more likely to remain engaged and committed. The question is always "How can we help?" - never "Why aren't you attending?"
ENLIGHTEN	Deepening understanding, curiosity, and enjoyment of Freemasonry. Mentoring does not end with the Third Degree; it is a lifelong opportunity to help Brethren appreciate Freemasonry - its purpose, traditions and meaning - rather than simply learn information.

These four principles are not sequential stages. They apply continuously and simultaneously throughout a member's journey - from applicant to Entered Apprentice, through each degree, into the Royal Arch, into office, through the Chair and beyond it.

The Lodge Mentor co-ordinates; the Personal Mentor accompanies; but the responsibility belongs to every member of every Lodge. "We are all mentors to others in Freemasonry."

A Lodge that embeds these principles into its culture, not only into the work of its Lodge Mentor, is a Lodge in which members thrive and remain.

4 The Member's Journey

Mentoring follows the member through his Masonic life and adapts to his needs at each stage. The pages that follow set out the key moments and the actions and conversations good mentoring should include. They are prompts, not a checklist to be ticked. The Personal Mentor's Guide covers the same journey from the one-to-one perspective, and the Stage Checklists give one-page versions for the night itself.

Two rules run through every stage. First, there should never be any surprises: a member should always know what is coming next. Second, the member sets the pace, never the calendar.

4.1 Before Initiation

Mentoring begins before the ballot, ideally from the moment a candidate is first proposed. The Lodge Mentor should be involved early, working with the Proposer, Seconder and Secretary.

Before the ballot

- Encourage the Lodge to get to know the candidate at informal social occasions before the formal interview, so that he arrives for interview among friends rather than strangers
- Ensure the interview is thorough and honest and covers the practical matters: costs and subscriptions, meeting frequency and timing, the Lodge of Instruction, the time commitment if he takes office, and the importance of a supportive partner or family
- Be open about what Freemasonry is and is not. A well-informed candidate makes a better long-term member
- Make sure he has introductory literature before the ballot

After the ballot

- Assign a Personal Mentor as soon as possible after election, and open his Personal Mentoring Plan
- Meet the candidate socially, with other members, as often as practical before his Initiation
- Involve his partner or family in social occasions where appropriate
- Prepare him for the evening: timings, what he will be asked to do, what to wear, what to bring, and the general shape of the evening, without spoiling the ceremony itself
- Contact him the day before, or on the day, to reassure him and answer last-minute questions

> **Good practice.** Introduce the candidate to the Tyler and the Junior Deacon immediately before the ceremony. Both can reassure him and make sure he does not feel isolated while he is outside the Lodge.

4.2 The Initiation and immediately after

The evening of Initiation is one of the most formative experiences of a member's Masonic life. Everything that happens, in the ceremony, at the Festive Board and in the days that follow, shapes his early impression of Freemasonry.

During the evening

- Seat the Personal Mentor next to, or as close as possible to, the Initiate so he can offer quiet reassurance and explanation as the evening unfolds
- Prepare him for the Festive Board: how Masonic Fire works, the order of toasts, and what he will be expected to say. Give him a draft speech in advance that he can adapt
- The first Festive Board can be daunting. Seat him comfortably, among people he has met, and make sure he is never left alone

Shortly after Initiation

A quick call or message within a day or two, and a proper one-to-one before the next Lodge meeting. That first meeting is critical. It should be relaxed, at his pace, and include:

- An open question first: "What did you make of the evening?" Then let him talk
- A review of the ceremony: what happened and, in general terms, why
- A chance to ask anything at all

- An introduction to the test questions he will need before his Passing, and how he will be helped to learn them
- A look through the Initiate's Guide, which he should have been given after the ceremony
- How the Lodge is organised: officers, their roles, how to recognise them, and where the Lodge sits within Province and Grand Lodge
- Masonic etiquette: the Risings, conduct at the Festive Board, and the customs of the Lodge
- An introduction to the charitable work of Freemasonry
- Solomon, and how to sign up

> **Key principle.** The role of Brother Initiate can feel very lonely. Unfamiliar sights, unfamiliar language, unfamiliar people. Our task as mentors is to dispel that strangeness as quickly as possible, through warmth, explanation and genuine friendship.

4.3 Between degrees

When the Lodge meets in a higher degree and the Entered Apprentice cannot be present, the evening is an ideal opportunity for structured Masonic education, not dead time. The Personal Mentor should:

- Arrange to meet him on the evening of the Lodge meeting, or at another convenient time, for companionship and learning
- Use the time for Masonic history, the meaning of the First Degree, the structure of Freemasonry, or whatever he is curious about
- Make sure he is using Solomon and has begun to explore it
- Keep in frequent, informal contact. Regular check-ins make the difference between a member who feels included and one who quietly drifts

The Lodge Mentor should watch this period closely. National evidence shows that many losses occur within two years of Initiation, often before Raising, and that candidates initiated in the spring are at extra risk because the summer break interrupts their early participation. Plan deliberate summer contact and social touchpoints for spring Initiates.

4.4 After Passing to Fellow Craft

The Second Degree is sometimes called the forgotten degree. It should not be. After his Passing the Personal Mentor should:

- Review the ceremony with him: what happened and what it signifies
- Talk through the differences he will have noticed between his Initiation and his Passing, and why they exist
- Discuss the Liberal Arts and Sciences and their relevance to everyday life
- Make sure he can give the Sign, Token and Word of a Fellow Craft correctly, as taught in the Lodge
- Explain the different aprons and what they signify
- Make sure he has received the Fellow Craft's Guide
- Encourage visiting; he may now do so freely
- Begin preparing him for the Third Degree, including the test questions, at his pace

> **Good practice.** Arrange for the Fellow Craft to witness a Passing in another Lodge as soon as convenient. Seeing the ceremony from the outside deepens understanding enormously.

4.5 After Raising to Master Mason

The Raising is a milestone, but it is a beginning, not a summit. The months after the Third Degree are one of the two recognised drop-out windows. Mentoring should intensify here, not fade.

After the Raising

- Review the ceremony: the essence of the Third Degree and its central teaching
- Make sure he can give the Grip and the Five Points of Fellowship correctly, as taught in the Lodge
- Explain how to sign in when visiting, and the caution needed in Lodges under other Constitutions
- Explain that Lodges work differently; he should observe before judging, and never criticise another Lodge's working
- Cover the etiquette of responding to the Visitors' Toast, and the importance of thanking hosts promptly
- Check he understands the structure of Grand Lodge and Provincial Grand Lodge and knows their principal Rulers
- Make sure he has received the Master Mason's Guide

In the months that follow

- Encourage regular attendance at the Lodge of Instruction

- Encourage visiting across the Province and beyond; offer to go with him the first time
- Introduce him to Provincial events, the Fleet House Light Blues Club and DAWG
- Support him in exploring whatever in Freemasonry interests him
- Make sure the Royal Arch has been explained as the completion of his journey, on his timing (Section 6)
- Begin gentle, open conversations about whether and when he might like to take office. Both answers are valid

> **Key principle.** Brethren who visit other Lodges, attend Provincial events and build friendships across the Province are more confident, better informed and far more likely to stay. Isolation is one of the earliest predictors of disengagement.

4.6 Into progressive office

When a member is offered his first office, the Lodge Mentor and Personal Mentor should make sure he is properly supported:

- Confirm he is genuinely ready and willing. Never pressure a member into office before he is confident
- Make sure he understands the responsibilities, time commitment and ritual requirements of the office
- Arrange ritual support from experienced members, and make sure he knows the DC and Preceptor are on his side
- Support regular attendance at the Lodge of Instruction
- Check in as he progresses, and be alert to anxiety or fading confidence

Progressive office is exciting, but it can be daunting, particularly for members who lack confidence in ritual or public speaking. Support must be available, not assumed. Readiness runs in both directions: the Brother pushed too early and the capable Brother left waiting both need your attention (see 8.2).

4.7 The Chair and beyond

Mentoring does not end when a member becomes Worshipful Master, or when he leaves the Chair. Every stage brings new experiences and new questions.

- A Master Elect benefits from preparation for the year: managing the Lodge, leading meetings, working with his officers, and looking after his own wellbeing

- From Installation day, prepare him for what follows the Chair. The year after the Chair is the second recognised risk window
- Past Masters often feel a loss of purpose. Keep them Included, Involved and Interested: a role, a project, a Brother to mentor
- Members taking on Provincial or other wider roles should be prepared and supported
- Long-standing members develop new questions about symbolism, history or the Royal Arch. Welcome them

> **Key principle.** Every Brother should want others to succeed, in Freemasonry and in life. The best Lodges are those in which experienced members invest in those coming behind them. Past Masters make excellent Personal Mentors. That is mentoring in its truest sense.

4.8 Joining members, re-joiners and dual members

Not every new member is an Initiate. A Brother who joins from another Lodge arrives as an experienced Mason but a stranger to this one, and the risk is that the Lodge assumes he needs nothing. He does. He needs a friend, and he needs to learn how this Lodge works.

Joining members

- Assign a Personal Mentor for at least his first year, chosen as a guide to the Lodge rather than a teacher of Freemasonry
- Open a Personal Mentoring Plan and mark it as a joining-member route; the early-degree stages do not apply
- Cover the things nobody thinks to explain: the Lodge's customs and working, dining arrangements, dress, who is who, how the Lodge communicates, and the calendar
- Ask what he wants from his membership. Some join for office, some for friendship, some for a quieter Masonic life. Do not assume, and do not press him into the progression ladder
- If he has come from another Province, he may be arriving through the Member Migration Process. Close the loop with the Provincial Grand Mentor's office so the sending Lodge knows he has landed safely
- Introduce him at the Festive Board and make sure he is not sitting alone for his first few meetings

Re-joiners

- A Brother returning after resignation is a success story in the making. Understand, gently, why he left and what is different now
- Treat him as a joining member for mentoring purposes, and be alert to whatever caused the earlier loss recurring
- He may have missed changes in the Lodge, the Province or Grand Lodge practice. Bring him up to date without fuss

Dual and multiple members

- Watch the diary. A Brother with two Lodges can be asked to do too much by both. Talk to his other Lodge Mentor where you can
- Never let two Lodges progress him to office at the same time unless he genuinely wants it
- Make sure he still feels he belongs here, and is not simply a visitor with a subscription

5 Supporting Learning

One of the most important functions of mentoring is helping members learn and understand Freemasonry. Accurate, consistent learning builds confidence and enjoyment. Inaccurate or inconsistent learning breeds confusion, frustration and disengagement. Mentoring supports two kinds of learning.

5.1 Guided learning

Guided learning is what a member needs to know to take part fully and confidently in Lodge life:

- The signs, tokens and words of each degree, as taught in the Lodge
- Test questions and answers before progression
- Ritual and ceremony relevant to an office or degree
- Lodge etiquette, protocol and procedure
- The structure of English Freemasonry and the role of its officers

Guided learning should be planned, accurate and delivered or overseen by those with the experience to do it well. The Lodge of Instruction is the natural home for it. Lodge Mentors should work with the Preceptor and DC so that LoI is welcoming to junior Brethren and not only a rehearsal for officers.

5.2 Personal learning

Personal learning is what the individual member wishes to explore for his own curiosity and fulfilment: the history and symbolism of Freemasonry; the meaning of ceremony, regalia and ritual; the story of the Lodge itself; the Royal Arch and the rest of Pure Antient Masonry. It is led by his interests, continues throughout his Masonic life, and should be welcomed. Interpretation is offered with humility: different Brethren read a symbol differently, and none of them wrongly.

5.3 Solomon and Archway

Solomon is UGLE's online learning platform and the primary authoritative resource for members in England. Lodge Mentors and Personal Mentors should use it and point members to it.

- Solomon contains accurate, UGLE-approved material for every stage
- It is available online at solomon.ugle.org.uk; where digital access is difficult, print from it
- Use it alongside, never instead of, face-to-face conversation
- Archway, UGLE's developing Royal Arch resource, sits alongside Solomon for One Journey material. Check its current status with the Provincial Office

Steer members away from unverified online content, speculation and material from other Masonic traditions. When in doubt, refer to Solomon or ask the Provincial Grand Mentor's office.

> **The ritual standard.** Hertfordshire mentoring documents never reveal ritual. Prepare a member for what a ceremony will ask of him practically, and let the ceremony do what it is designed to do. Never expose a non-Mason to signs, tokens or words, including when a member is learning ritual at home.

6 The Royal Arch: One Journey

UGLE describes the Royal Arch as the completion of Pure Antient Masonry, and encourages Master Masons to complete that journey before joining other orders. Hertfordshire's approach is called One Journey. Its purpose is education and timing, never pressure. The most common failure is a Brother who reaches the Chair having never had the Royal Arch explained to him, and who then hears it as a sales pitch rather than the natural close of the path he began on his Initiation night.

6.1 Four bridging points

Mentoring closes the gap between Craft and Chapter at four moments. The Lodge Mentor makes sure each one happens.

When	What the mentor does
At Initiation	The Provincial Welcome Letter and the Personal Mentor's early conversations frame Freemasonry as a four-part journey from the start. The Royal Arch is never a surprise.
Through progression	As he is passed and raised, the mentor places each step in the wider journey, so the Royal Arch is anticipated rather than introduced cold.
Around the Third Degree	The mentor makes sure he knows UGLE's encouragement to complete the journey in Pure Antient Masonry, and knows that the choice, and its timing, are his alone.
Through the Royal Arch Representative	Every Craft Lodge has one. The Lodge Mentor works with him so that information is shared, accurate and consistent, and so that a Brother who expresses interest is introduced to a Chapter warmly.

6.2 Two rules for the conversation

> **Timing, not inevitability.** Introduce the Royal Arch when the member has consolidated his understanding of the Craft, has shown curiosity or asked questions, and has room in his life for a further commitment. Never rush it, and never assume it.

> **Information, not recruitment.** Tell him clearly what the Royal Arch is, what to expect, and what the time and cost involve. Reassure him that the Craft is complete and valuable in itself. He must never be made to feel an incomplete Freemason without it.

6.3 Why it matters for retention

Members who join the Royal Arch are demonstrably more likely to stay engaged with their Craft Lodges. A Brother who sees a path ahead of him stays; one who believes he has reached the end of the road is the one most at risk. One Journey therefore serves the same end as everything else in this guide.

The Provincial Mentoring Team works with the Provincial Grand Chapter so that One Journey messaging is shared, not parallel. A bridge built from only one side does not meet in the middle. The Provincial Grand Mentor's office can advise on any specific situation.

7 Retention and Warning Signs

Most resignations are preceded by warning signs. Noticed early and acted on warmly, they can be addressed before disengagement becomes irreversible. Where exit conversations happen, roughly one resignation in three is recovered. Early action prevents resignations; late action rarely does.

This section is a summary. The Retention, Retrieval and Migration Guide is the owner-document, covering the rules on resignation (Rule 183), unattached Brethren (Rule 127), the retrieval conversation and lessons learned. The Warning Signs card carries the essentials on one page for every mentor's pocket.

7.1 The pattern is the signal

Risk shows as a break in a member's own pattern, not as a low absolute level of attendance. A Brother who has always attended twice a year is content; a stalwart who stops coming is not. The Secretary's attendance record, shared after each meeting, is your early-warning system, and the Personal Mentor is the person who will hear the real reason behind the stated one.

Watch for	Signs
Attendance patterns	Two or more consecutive meetings missed without explanation; habitual late arrival or early departure; attending only Installations or social events; ceasing to visit; a summer absence that extends into autumn.
Participation changes	Reluctance to accept work or office; withdrawal from conversation; missing LoI while holding office; loss of preparation where it was once a point of pride; visible unhappiness in meetings.
Communication indicators	Unanswered calls and messages; expressed frustration or disillusionment; repeated mention of time or money pressures; unfavourable comparison with other commitments; subscription arrears.

7.2 The four steps

Graduated, warm and mostly invisible. Most concerns are resolved at Step 1 and never look like a process at all.

Step 1	Personal Mentor: friendly, informal contact. After any unexpected absence, a call or message to say he was missed. After two consecutive misses, contact within seven days of the second meeting.
Step 2	Lodge Mentor involved. Takes the overview, considers what the Lodge itself could change (timing, cost, culture, an office that does not fit), keeps a discreet note, and closes the loop with the member.
Step 3	Worshipful Master's conversation. Where the matter touches Lodge culture, office or relations with another member. The Almoner alongside for anything touching welfare.
Step 4	Provincial referral. Where an impartial voice helps, or where the member might thrive in a different Lodge. Contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office. Referral is responsible mentoring, not failure.

7.3 When a member says he may resign

A resignation letter is the beginning of a conversation, not the end of one. The Secretary acknowledges receipt only; he cannot accept a resignation. The Almoner, the Lodge Mentor and the Provincial Office are told the same day. Within the window the rules allow, the best-placed person has an unhurried, private conversation whose purpose is understanding, not persuasion. Alternatives worth exploring include reduced involvement for a season, a leave of absence, stepping back from office, or a transfer to a Lodge that fits him better. Retrieval for the Craft matters more than retention in one Lodge.

If he still chooses to go, part with warmth and gratitude. How a Lodge handles a departure is watched by every member who stays. See the Retention, Retrieval and Migration Guide, Sections 5 and 6.

> **Key principle.** The question is always "How can we help?", never "Why aren't you attending?"

8 Managing Challenges and Escalation

Lodge Mentors will meet situations that are sensitive, complex or beyond what the Lodge can reasonably resolve. Knowing when and how to escalate is part of the role.

8.1 When to seek Provincial support

Contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office, or your Assistant Provincial Grand Mentor, when:

- A member is at significant risk of resignation and Lodge-level support has not been enough
- A situation involves welfare that may need the Almoner and Provincial officers
- A complaint or dispute in the Lodge has a mentoring dimension
- A Lodge is seeing several resignations or a pattern of early disengagement
- You would like coaching, advice or a second opinion on a difficult situation
- A member is relocating and needs migration support

Escalation is responsible mentoring. The Province exists to support Lodges, not to judge them, and all contact is treated in confidence.

8.2 Protecting members from pressure, in both directions

Pressure runs two ways. The member pushed too hard and the member left under-stretched are both at risk, and the Lodge Mentor watches for both.

The member pushed too hard

- Pressure to accept office before he feels ready or confident
- Pressure to deliver ritual beyond his current ability
- Pressure to progress through the degrees faster than he wishes
- Pressure to join the Royal Arch or other orders before the time is right
- Any behaviour that makes a member feel inadequate, unwelcome or judged

The Provincial Mentoring Framework is clear that outdated practices, including a "sink or swim" approach, discouraging visiting, or creating unnecessary mystique, run counter to UGLE guidance and the principles of Freemasonry. Where you see them, address them sensitively but directly, and escalate to the Worshipful Master or the Province if necessary.

The member left under-stretched

Less visible, and just as costly. Signs include:

- A capable Brother waiting years for a first office in a Lodge with a long queue, or with Past Masters who prefer to hold the offices themselves
- A Brother who was never asked: to visit, to take a small piece of ritual, to help with a project
- A Past Master with nothing to do, or a joining member whose experience nobody thought to use
- A Master Mason of several years who has stopped learning because nobody offered him anything to learn

What to do: talk to him about what he would like; find him a role that fits, in the Lodge, at LoI, in the Province or in mentoring itself; raise the office queue with the Worshipful Master and the DC; and if the Lodge genuinely cannot offer him what he needs, talk to the Province about whether he might flourish in a second Lodge. A Brother who is bored will leave as surely as one who is frightened.

8.3 Confidentiality and records

Lodge Mentors and Personal Mentors receive sensitive information in confidence. Handle it with care:

- Record only what mentoring needs: contact details, key dates, milestones and brief notes of support given. The Personal Mentoring Plan is the record; the Personal Mentor's own notes are kept to a minimum
- The member knows a plan is kept, what it contains, and may see it on request
- Welfare matters belong to the Almoner's records. The mentoring plan notes only "referred to Almoner"
- Keep records secure, whether paper or digital, and do not circulate them
- Disclose confidential information only where the member's interests genuinely require it or where a safeguarding concern exists
- On handover, brief your successor and pass the plans on; close and securely destroy a plan within a defined period after a member resigns, migrates or dies

The Style, Terminology and Data Guide sets out the Province's data rules for mentoring records in full.

9 Migration

Relocation is one of the most common causes of loss, and one of the clearest opportunities to keep a member in Freemasonry. Migration is a continuation of mentoring, not an administrative exercise. The Retention, Retrieval and Migration Guide, Section 7, is the owner-document; the essentials for the Lodge Mentor are these.

- Identify early. Mentors ask about house and job moves as a matter of course, and act on hints in conversation or changes in availability
- Have a positive conversation about continuing Freemasonry in the new area, and contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office to start the Member Migration Process
- Encourage him to stay a member here until he has joined his new Lodge, so his service is unbroken
- Hand over mentoring information sensitively and with regard to confidentiality
- Stay in touch until he is settled. The sending Lodge's duty ends when he is happily at home in his new Lodge, not at the county boundary

Hertfordshire also receives migrating Brethren. Treat an inbound migrant as a joining member (4.8) and confirm his safe arrival to the Provincial Grand Mentor's office so the loop is closed for the sending Lodge.

> **Key principle.** A member who feels warmly supported and positively handed over to a new Lodge is a member who stays in Freemasonry. One who feels dropped or forgotten is not.

10 Working With Other Lodge Officers

Mentoring is a shared Lodge culture, and several officers hold a piece of it. The Lodge Mentor's job is to make sure the pieces connect. A short, regular conversation with each of the officers below, and a place on the agenda of the Lodge Committee, is usually all it takes.

Officer	Working together
Worshipful Master	Sets the tone of the Lodge and owns Step 3 conversations. Ask him to hear your report with the same weight as the Treasurer's, to brief the Lodge on mentoring once a year, and to protect junior Brethren from pressure.
Almoner	Leads on welfare: health, money, bereavement and family, and on contact with non-attenders and former members. Welcome new members jointly. Refer anything touching welfare to him and note only "referred to Almoner". He leads within the Rule 183 window where welfare is the cause.
Membership Officer	Holds the Lodge's membership picture and the pipeline of candidates. Agree how early you are told of a new enquiry, review joiners and leavers together at least annually, and share lessons learned.

Director of Ceremonies	Owns ceremony preparation and the culture of LoI. Agree how candidates are prepared for the practical side of each ceremony, how junior Brethren are drawn into ritual gently, and how the office queue is managed fairly.
Secretary	Holds the candidate timeline that mentoring hangs from, and the attendance record. Ask for the attendance record after each meeting, for early notice of ballots, and for same-day notice of any resignation.
Treasurer	Often the first to see hard evidence of disengagement: subscriptions falling into arrears. Agree that a first missed subscription earns a quiet word to you or the Almoner, long before any formal process.
Royal Arch Representative	One Journey's bridge in the Lodge. Agree what is said about the Royal Arch, when, and by whom, so that information is consistent and interest is met with a warm introduction to a Chapter.
Preceptor of the LoI	Where the Preceptor is not the DC, agree how new members are welcomed at LoI and how learning is paced to the member rather than the calendar.

11 Provincial Support and Resources

The Province is committed to Lodge Mentors being well supported, well equipped and well connected. The following is available to you.

Support	What it offers
Induction for new Lodge Mentors	Every newly appointed Lodge Mentor is invited to an induction covering the role, the library and how to reach the Province, and receives the Lodge Mentor's Charge. If you have not had yours, contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office.
Your Assistant Provincial Grand Mentor	One for each APGM area. Your nearest source of advice, a visitor at Initiations, and the route for your quarterly picture of mentoring in the Lodge.
Monthly mentoring call	Hosted by the Deputy Provincial Grand Mentor on the first Tuesday of the month at 7pm by Teams, open to all Lodge Mentors and Personal Mentors. Questions, shared experience and news from the Provincial team.

Personal Mentor workshop	A short skills workshop for Personal Mentors: asking good questions, listening, and the conversations that matter. Bring your Personal Mentors.
Combined Mentoring and Learning and Development meetings	Twice-yearly Provincial events for new Brethren, bringing together mentoring and Learning and Development. Encourage every new member to attend one.
The Visitors' Festival	Each year the Provincial team selects an exemplary First, Second and Third Degree ceremony for newly initiated, passed and raised Brethren to attend as visitors, seated with the Provincial Mentoring Team.
The Welcome Letter	Every new Initiate receives a personal letter from the Provincial team shortly after his Initiation. Make sure the Secretary has sent the details promptly.
Mentoring and Membership Past Masters' Lodge	Meets twice a year as the formal meeting point for mentoring, membership and Learning and Development across the Province.
Mentor's Jewel	Presented, with its explanation, to every Brother appointed Lodge Mentor.
DAWG	The Daily Advancement WhatsApp Group, run by the Provincial Mentoring Team: a daily piece of Masonic interest and a community of mentors.
Solomon and Archway	UGLE's learning platform (solomon.ugle.org.uk) and its Royal Arch resource.
The mentoring library	The companion documents listed in 1.2, updated at each issue and available from the Provincial Grand Mentor's office and the Provincial website.
One-to-one support	For a specific situation, a difficult conversation or simply to think aloud, contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office directly. All contact is in confidence.

12 Contact Information

Provincial Grand Mentor	W Bro Mark Butcher, via the Provincial Office
Deputy Provincial Grand Mentor	W Bro Wes Pierce, via the Provincial Office

Mentoring email	mentor@hertfordshirefreemasons.org.uk
Provincial Office	Fleet House, 10 Parkway, St Albans, AL3 6PA
Telephone	01727 833061
Website	www.pgherts.org
Solomon (UGLE learning)	solomon.ugle.org.uk
UGLE Building Together	Via the UGLE members' website

This guide is reviewed and updated periodically. If you have suggestions for improvement, or find something that needs correcting, please contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office. Corrections are collected in the Corrections Register and applied at the next issue.

13 Quick Reference: The Lodge Mentor's Year

A one-page rhythm for the role. Adapt it to your Lodge's calendar.

When	What
Every meeting	Check every candidate and new member has a Personal Mentor and a Plan. Collect the attendance record from the Secretary. Note any pattern-breaks and pass them to the Personal Mentor within seven days. Make sure no new or joining member dines alone.
Every month	Join the Provincial mentoring call. A short word with each Personal Mentor: how is he getting on, does he need anything. Check the DAWG.
Every quarter	Update your Assistant Provincial Grand Mentor. Review Plans with Personal Mentors. Check the office queue and the under-stretched with the WM and DC.
Before each ceremony	Work through the Stage Checklist with the Personal Mentor. Confirm the candidate has been contacted the day before.
After each ceremony	Confirm the check-in and the first one-to-one have happened. Confirm the Welcome Letter has gone (Initiations).
Installation	Prepare the Master Elect for the year and for what follows it. Speak to the outgoing Master about his next role. Confirm a Past Master or two as Personal Mentors.

Summer	Deliberate contact and a social touchpoint for every spring Initiate and Entered Apprentice.
Once a year	Brief the whole Lodge on mentoring. Review joiners and leavers with the Membership Officer. Review records, destroy what is no longer needed, and brief your likely successor. Attend the Personal Mentor workshop with your team.

Prepare • Guide • Support • Enlighten

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